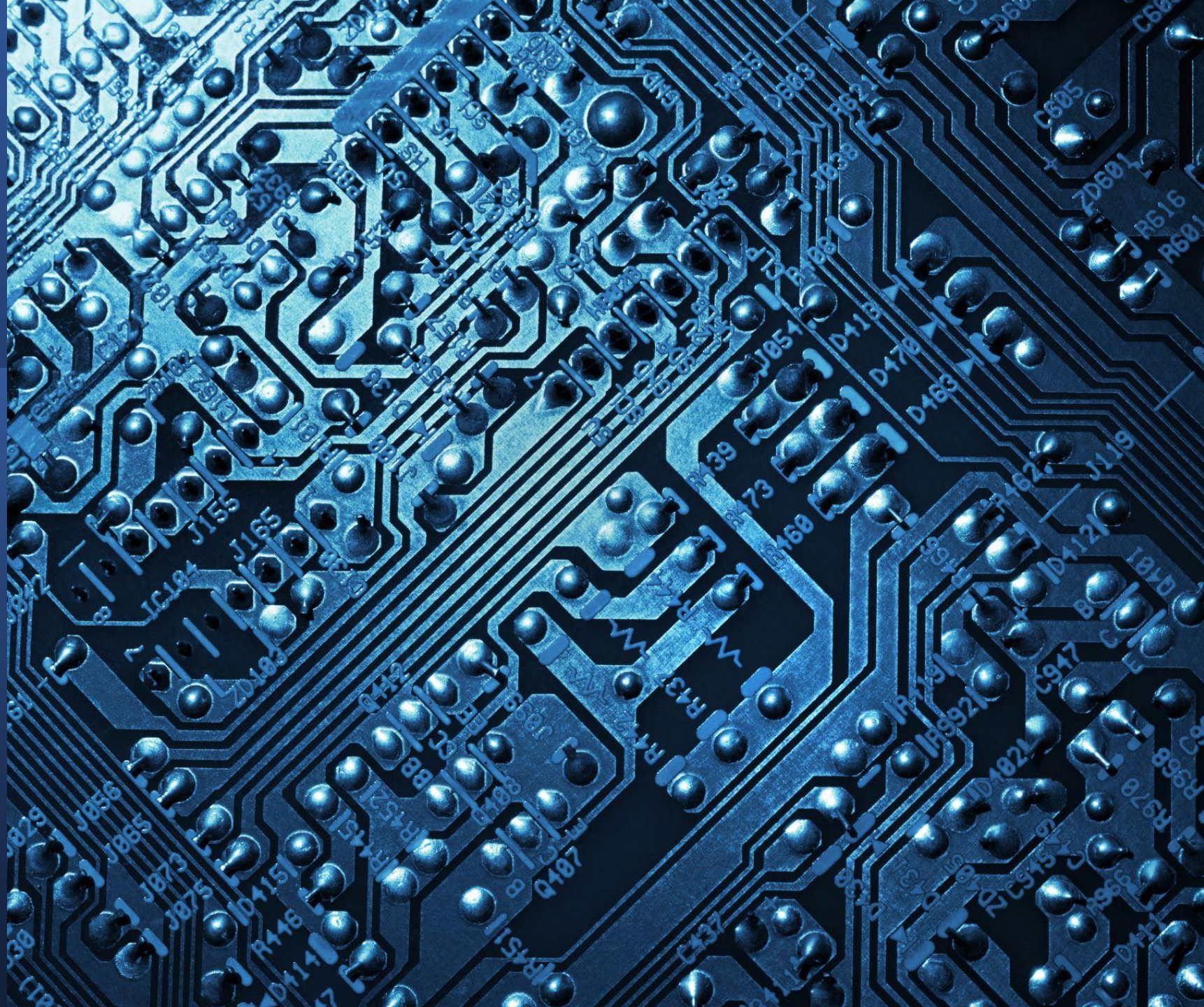


Autism in Tech

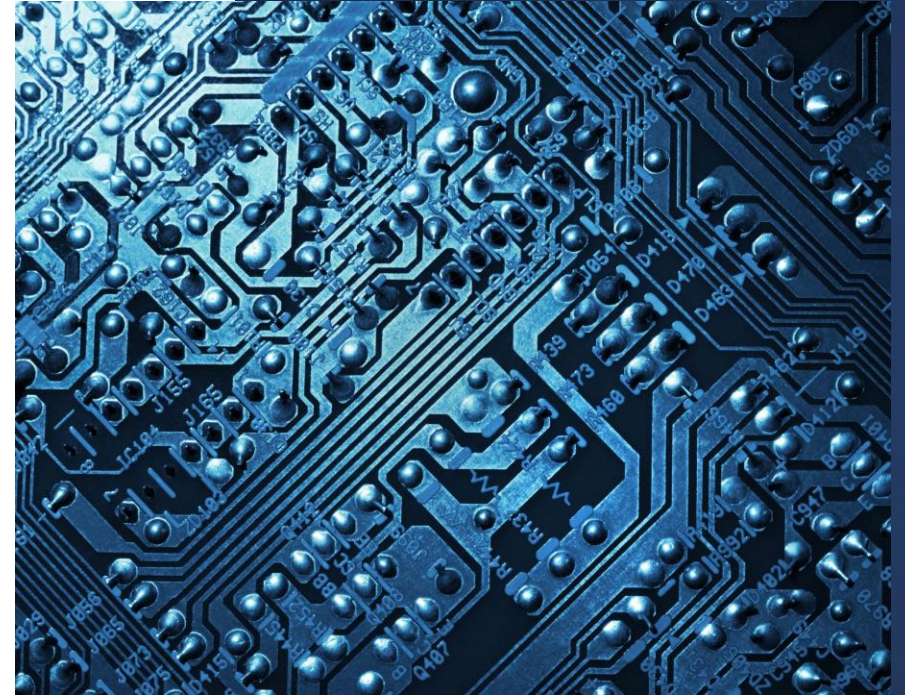
@DennieDeclercq // 2021

PGI – Most Valuable Community :-)



Content

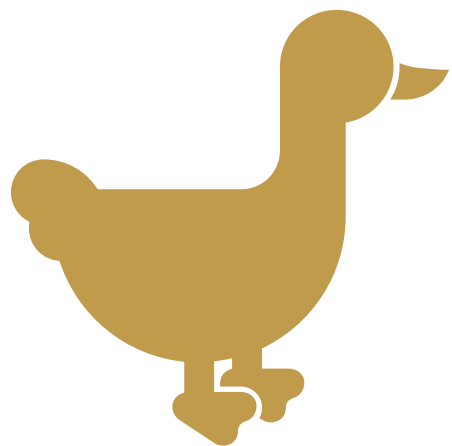
- Who am I?
- I am different
- The Autist' Brain
- Myths & Beyond
- Autism in Tech:
 - Executive Functioning in Tech
 - Central Coherence in Tech
 - Theory of Mind in Tech
 - Co-Morbid in Tech
- What worked for me?
- Wrap up
- Thanks // Q&A



Who am I?

- Dennie Declercq
- DDSoft
- President / Developer
- @DennieDeclercq
- #DreamingIsBelieving





I am different

Autistic

- Different since I was a child
- Autism diagnose at age of 13
- No university college



Without a paid job

- 2008 – 2011: Tried some jobs
- No science degree
- Factory for people with disabilities
- Tech / development in after hours
- Ended on a sickness benefit



A tech lover

- Very passionate
- Fanatic pro Microsoft
- Windows Mobile
- Why did Windows Phone die?
- Windows 3.1 → 10
- VB6 → C#



How did I roll into tech world?

- 15yo: I wanted to be a developer
- Microsoft Office at school
- Mike was a programmer
- Don't have the feeling with PHP, JavaScript, Java
- 2012: Volunteer developer
- Belgian community
- 2014: DDSOFT
- 2017: Started as conference speaker
- 2019: Microsoft MVP



Autistic logic & Developers logic

fx

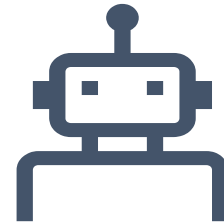
Developers Logic

A Boolean is true or false

It's good to declare variables, what type it's expected

If you program a loop, the exit scenario should be clear

It's very structured



Autistic Logic

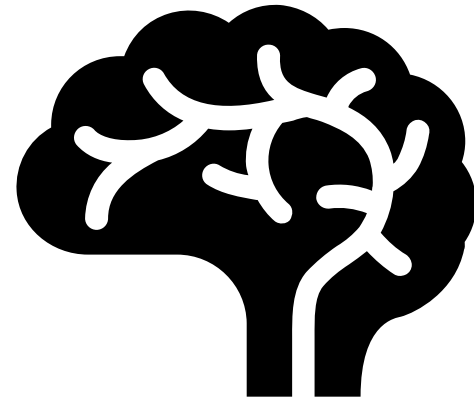
A fact is only true or false

It's very nice that every circumstance is declared

If there's a path to follow, auti's like it's clear and clean

Most of them are very structured

The Autist' Brain



Theory of Mind

- Understanding the WHY
- Seeing which behavior causes which outcome
- Seeing logical steps

Executive Functioning

- Everything that you need in daily living or in a working environment
- Examples:
 - Planning a timeslot
 - Planning what to wear at a conference, meeting
 - Planning which sessions, you want to see

Central Coherence

- Coherence of situations, things, tasks, words
- Seeing the global picture

Context Blindness

- Understanding the context of something
- 'One incentive has one meaning'
- Problems with 'use of the same words' for other meanings

Basic solution

- Explaining, Explaining & Explaining
- Trying to understand
- Trying to figure out

Extra: Co-morbid diagnosis

- Extra medical conditions
 - Extra stress
 - Anxiety
 - Depression
 - ADHD

Autism / ASD: Disability or Neurodiversity?

- Thought leadership on autism changed
- People with autism / Asperger's are superpowers
- Good for inclusion
- People with autism need to know their self very good.
- Example: Greta Thunberg



Paid job or volunteer job?

- Paid job is sometimes possible
- Not always
- Advice: Start with QoL “Quality of Life” and Basic comfortable feeling



Executive functioning in tech





Different energy
and new
technologies



Code Style

- People with autism think straight forward
 - My way of the highway
 - Can be sure they use the best classes, procedures
- Difficult to change code style
 - New possibilities in C#
 - Difficult to adapt some patterns.

```
private bool CheckInternetConnection()
{
    //Xamarin.Essentials: Connectivity
    var connection = Connectivity.NetworkAccess.InternetAvailable;
    if(connection == NetworkAccess.InternetAvailable)
    {
        NoConnectionButton.IsVisible = false;
        return true;
    }
    else
    {
        NoConnectionButton.IsVisible = true;
        return false;
    }
}
```

Code patterns



Structure

- Day Structure
 - Huge change of different day structure
 - More breaks during day
- Project timeframe

Central Coherence in Tech





Covid19 &
Virtual
conferences

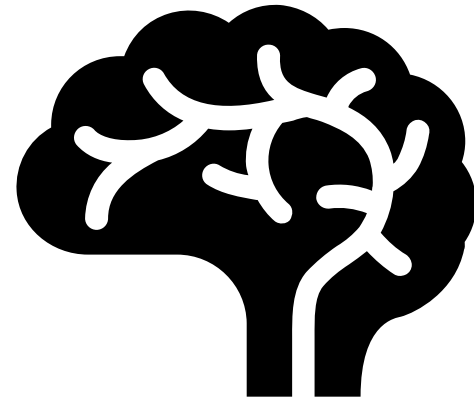


Cross – software solutions


```
Selection View Go Debug Terminal Help _Host.cshtml - Visual  
st.cshtml X  
DSoft > Projects > Blazor > Bethanys > 02 > demos > Demos > End > Bethany  
@page "/"  
@namespace BethanysPieShopHRM.Server.Pages  
@addTagHelper *, Microsoft.AspNetCore.Mvc.TagHelpers  
  
<!DOCTYPE html>  
<html lang="en">  
<head>  
    <meta charset="utf-8" />  
    <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, in  
    <title>BethanysPieShopHRM.Server</title>  
    <base href="~/>  
    <link rel="stylesheet" href="css/bootstrap/bootstrap.  
    <link href="css/site.css" rel="stylesheet" />  
    <script src="https://kit.fontawesome.com/273d0585ea.j
```

Colors and IDE's

Theory of Mind in Tech





Being fanatic & user groups and conferences

- Can be an issue
- More difficult at conferences
 - Variety of topics / speakers



User groups & conferences and different communication

- Talking too much or too little
- Problems with eye contact
- Different non-verbal communication
 - Example: being excited but can't show

Being fanatic in tech

- Pro Microsoft / Apple / Linux?
 - Difficult to use both
 - C# / JavaScript
- Me: so happy with Blazor 😊
 - ASP.NET or PHP
 - Biased in apps / libraries



Stack Exchange Q&A communities are different. Here's how:



Expert communities.

Each of our 174 communities is built by people passionate about a focused topic.



The right answer. Right on top.

Experts like you can vote on posts, so the most helpful answers are easy to find.



Share knowledge. Earn trust.

Earn reputation and additional privileges for posts others find helpful.

[Learn more](#)

Forums and communication

- Difficult if you are fanatic
- Forum expect knowledge and DIY
- Was difficult in the beginning



DM's and communication

Big mismatch in communication



Code reviews

Difficult if you have a
different code style

GitHub | DDGuard

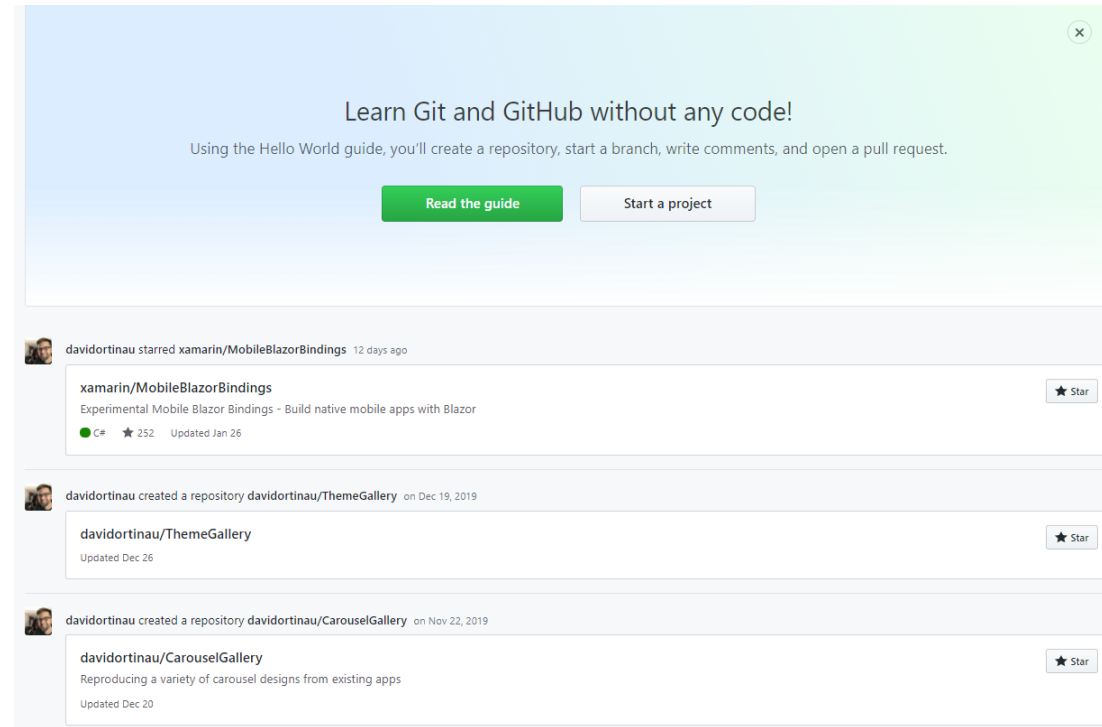
[0 Open](#) ▼ | [Create New](#)



There aren't any open pull requests

Pull requests let you tell others
about changes you've pushed to a
repository on GitHub

To get started you can [create a pull request](#)



Contributing OSS

- Can be a reason for not contributing to OSS.
- Being afraid to be different
- Afraid from criticism

Special topics of interest

- Can be very fanatic for an investment
 - Invest in:
 - Technology nobody cares about
 - Time in specific nice side project



Co-Morbid in Tech





Working on updates

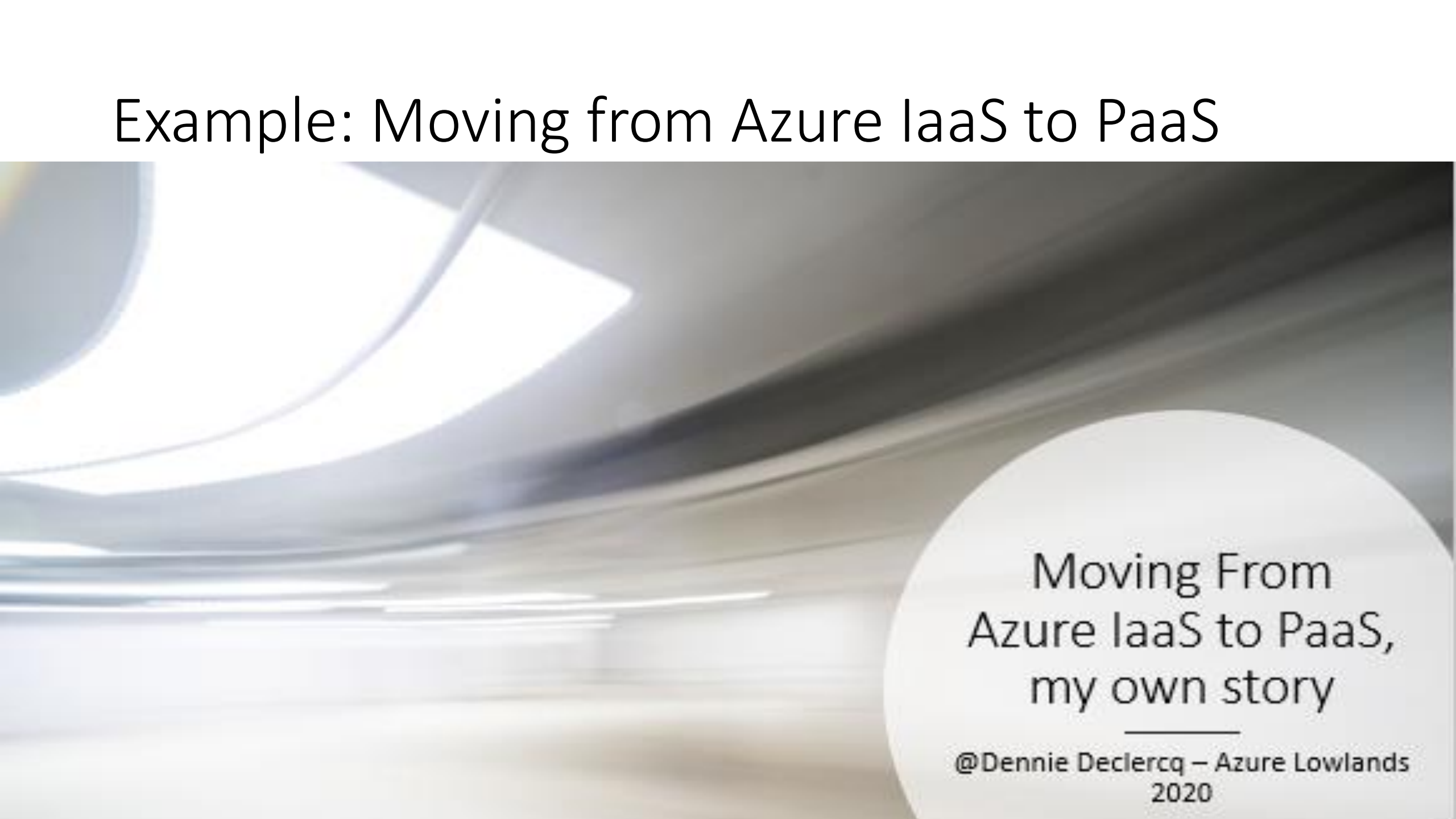
11% complete

Don't turn off your computer

Anxiety in tech

- Being afraid to change from tool stack
- Windows update
- Being afraid to ask questions in fora
- Being afraid to use public transport (too little time in the community)
- Cloud changes
- Being afraid of losing friends & Being fanatic
- Afraid of losing your job & own vision

Example: Moving from Azure IaaS to PaaS



Moving From
Azure IaaS to PaaS,
my own story

@Dennie Declercq – Azure Lowlands
2020

Example:
Xamarin.Forms



NETStandard.Library v2.0.3

A set of standard .NET A...



Xamarin.Essentials by v1.2.0

Xamarin.Essentials: a kit... v1.3.1



Xamarin.Forms v4.1.0.581479

Build native UIs f... v4.4.0.991537



What worked for me?

Welcome back, Dennie Declercq

Master core concepts at your speed and on your schedule. Whether you've got 15 minutes or an hour, you can develop practical skills through interactive modules and paths.



LEARNING PATHS

Learn on your own schedule

Explore a topic in-depth through guided paths or

CERTIFICATIONS

Become Microsoft certified

Jump-start your career and demonstrate your

LEARN TV

Watch live and recorded events

View streaming technical content about Microsoft products from the experts that build

Code style

- Community Leaders
- Interest
- Microsoft Learn
- Conference talks
- Pluralsight

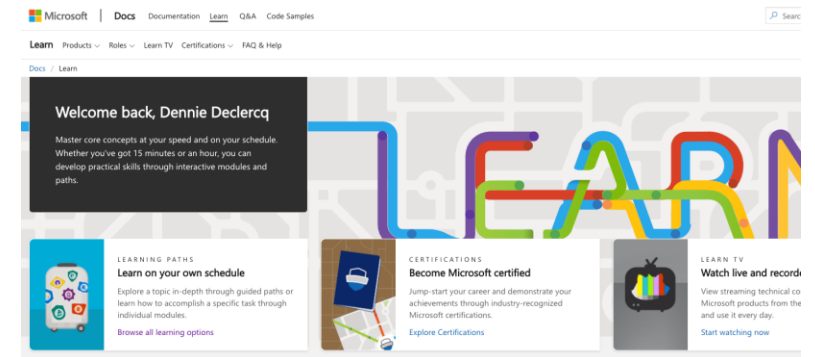
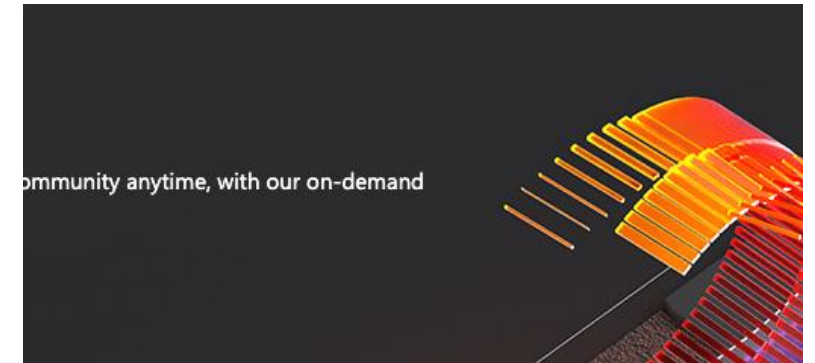
Colors

- The need and the urge
- The broad possibilities



New Technologies

- Focusing on interest
- The love of conferences
- The joy of being inspired
- Microsoft Learn



Windows / Mac

- The need and the urge
- Web versions look the same!
 - Thank Microsoft for Edge



Microsoft 365



Same 'source of truth'



Love the outlook calendar



Virtual commute in Teams



Praising in Teams



Wrap up

Thanks! Q&A

- Dennie Declercq
- @DennieDeclercq
- #DreamingIsBelieving
- dennie@ddsoft.be

